

Covering all the angles

Making a compelling business case is at the heart of innovation. Decisions will not get made on the basis of personality and passion alone—you need to be able to convince decision-makers to spend resources on a project that will work. Is there a market, will the technology work, can you protect the idea, what will it cost, and what are the likely benefits? Showing that you have thought the project through and have answers to any difficult questions they might throw at you will enhance your chances of a successful pitch.

BUILDING A GOOD BUSINESS CASE

FEATURE	WHAT TO INCLUDE
Outline your idea	A short and simple explanation of your idea—how it is new and what it will do. Remember it is not what you think but how “they” see it, so try and present it in terms of what it will do for them. You might try mapping it on a strategic position map.
Market analysis	Who is it targeted at? Who wants it, why do they need it, and why don’t they have it yet? How big is this market? Is it growing, declining, or static?
Competitors	Who else is out there, what do they offer, how will this idea get ahead of them, how might they react, and how do you protect yourself from that?
Why it will work	What do you know, and what prior knowledge, skills, experience, and networks can you bring to the table?
Rewards	What will you get if you succeed—money, market share, customer satisfaction—and how long you will have to wait until you get them?
Costs	How much will it cost, and what do you need to make it happen?
Risk factors	What might pose problems and how will you get around them?
Project management	Who will take this forward and how? What reassurances can you offer that you can do it?